

# CoverUp

TGC Game Jam 2026 | Final scope proposal (Hour 12) | Team: Packet Loss (5 members) | Engine: Phaser 3 + TypeScript + Vite | Repo: [github.com/SanjayAraval/BeamBoon](https://github.com/SanjayAraval/BeamBoon) (repo name predates the final concept)

## Team

| Member                    | Role                                                                                                        |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sanjay Araval (Team Lead) | Game director, core gameplay programming (flashlight, perception system, weapons), repo and itch.io release |
| Praneeth Koneru           | Gameplay programming: Act 2 systems (cover-up tasks, visitor events, paranoia meter)                        |
| Varenya Mulugu            | Art: comic panels, character and house art, ink and halftone style                                          |
| Varenya Vadrevu           | Audio, writing and UI: captions, dialogue, sound effects, ambient loop, menus                               |
| Kataboina Prajval         | Level design, comic montage assembly, endings, QA and playtesting                                           |

## 1. Concept

CoverUp is a dark psychological comic-noir game about a paranoid young man. After a zombie movie night pushes his paranoia over the edge, his drunk parents stumble home from a party and he mistakes them for the undead. It opens as a zombie survival game, the lights come on, and it turns into a tense game of managing the aftermath, as he tries to keep the truth from the neighbor and the police (his father is a cop) while his paranoia keeps bending what he sees. Every visitor tests whether he will repeat the same mistake. It is told as tragedy and dark comedy, not gore. All violence is off-panel, shown only as a black panel and a caption.

## 2. How it meets all three themes

- **Comic:** the whole game is a black and white ink comic. Scenes play out as panels with speech bubbles, caption boxes and onomatopoeia. An opening comic montage explains why he became paranoid.
- **Light:** the flashlight is the core mechanic. In the dark or under the beam, people appear as zombies. With the lights on, they appear as the people they are. Light controls what the player sees and what the character believes.
- **Twist:** the zombies were never real. The reveal is a small, ordinary detail (a party hat, a family photo, his mother saying his name). The game flips from a zombie shooter into a cover-up game, and the same art style turns from pulp horror into crime noir.

## 3. Structure (target 12 to 14 minutes)

| Part                | Length | Description                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|---------------------|--------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Opening montage     | 2 min  | Six comic panels showing why he became paranoid (horror movie shadow, outbreak news, a power cut, isolation, misread signals, the locked closet where his father, a police officer, keeps his service weapon). The player finds one clue per panel with the flashlight, which sets the starting paranoia level.                                                       |
| Movie night         | 1 min  | He watches a zombie film alone and his paranoia spikes. His drunk parents arrive home late from a party.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| Act 1: The Defense  | 2 min  | Zombie mode inside the house. Flashlight cone plus a knife for close range, then a limited-ammo gun taken from his father's closet. Dark means zombie, light means human. The shooting is off-panel (black panel and caption). The lights come on and the reveal lands.                                                                                               |
| Act 2: The Cover-Up | 7 min  | One night in a four-room house. Manage the aftermath and handle four visitor events (neighbor, patrol officer, father's partner, a final inspection). Each visitor is a test: talk and lie, or repeat the mistake. At high paranoia the visitor appears as a zombie and the weapon prompts appear. Attacking is possible but loud, adds evidence and raises paranoia. |

|          |            |                                                                                                                                                                              |
|----------|------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Epilogue | 1 to 2 min | Four comic-page endings based on noise, evidence and paranoia: Caught (jail), Run (flee to the woods), Clean (gets away with it) and Breakdown (the zombie view takes over). |
|----------|------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

## 4. Controls

Mouse to aim the flashlight, WASD or arrow keys to move, left click to attack or interact, E to switch weapon or pick up items, Space to toggle the light, R to restart the night. Touch input is a stretch goal only.

## 5. Locked scope

| Item         | Commitment                                                                                                                        |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Content      | Title screen, 6-panel montage, movie night, Act 1, Act 2 and 4 epilogue endings (jail and woods are endings, not separate levels) |
| Map          | One house with 4 rooms                                                                                                            |
| Mechanic 1   | Flashlight cone with a dual-perception system (zombie view vs human view)                                                         |
| Mechanic 2   | Two weapons: a knife (quiet, close range) and a gun (loud, 2 rounds). Noise level carries into Act 2                              |
| Mechanic 3   | Paranoia meter that drives light flicker and perception shifts                                                                    |
| Mechanic 4   | Cover-up tasks and 4 visitor events, each a talk-or-attack test (the same mistake again)                                          |
| Platform     | Browser playable (HTML5) on itch.io, desktop first                                                                                |
| Out of scope | Full jail-escape or woods-survival levels (stretch goal only), procedural generation, multiplayer, voice acting                   |

## 6. Art, audio and assets

- Art: black and white ink style with halftone shading, hand-drawn by the team or built from vector shapes in code. Any generated art is disclosed.
- Audio: CC0 or CC BY sound effects and a short ambient loop, all listed in CREDITS.md with source links and licenses.
- Fonts: open source comic fonts (for example Bangers, OFL). No paid assets.

## 7. AI use disclosure

- An LLM (Claude) is used for brainstorming, scoping, planning and help with code and debugging. Concept direction and design decisions are made by the team.
- Any AI generated image or audio will be labeled in CREDITS.md and on the itch.io page.

## 8. Milestones (100 hour window)

| Window          | Goal                                                                                  |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hours 0 to 12   | Repo, scope lock, Phaser boot, movement, flashlight cone prototype                    |
| Hours 12 to 30  | Dual-perception system (zombie vs human), knife and gun, Act 1 playable               |
| Hours 30 to 55  | Four-room house, paranoia meter, visitor events, Act 2 core loop, test itch.io upload |
| Hours 55 to 75  | Comic montage, endings, narration and caption system                                  |
| Hours 75 to 90  | Art and audio pass, balance, playtests                                                |
| Hours 90 to 100 | Bug fixes only, README, CREDITS.md, final itch.io build, code freeze                  |

## 9. Rule compliance

- Fresh codebase: only a generic Vite + TypeScript starter and the Phaser library are used. All game code is written inside the jam window, and every member commits from their own GitHub account so authorship is visible in the public history.
- Public repo with MIT license, README (itch.io link, setup, controls, team) and CREDITS.md in the root.
- Final deliverable: public browser build on itch.io with a complete 10 to 15 minute loop.